

Agent Teams & Background Agents

Introduced: v2.1.x (February 5, 2026) – Research Preview |
Latest: v2.1.53

What It Is

Agent Teams let you spawn multiple Claude instances (teammates) that work in parallel on different parts of a task. A lead session coordinates the work through a shared task list and mailbox. Each teammate has its own context window and can work independently. Background agents are a simpler variant – fire-and-forget subagents that run concurrently while you continue working.

Why It Matters

Some tasks are embarrassingly parallel: reviewing security, performance, and tests on the same PR. Agent teams let you: – 3 reviewers examine a PR simultaneously (security, perf, tests) – One agent refactors backend while another updates frontend – Background agents run linting/testing while you keep coding – Cut wall-clock time by 3x on parallel-friendly tasks

Quick Start (60 Seconds)

Agent Teams

```
# Enable agent teams (required – research preview)
export CLAUDE_CODE_EXPERIMENTAL_AGENT_TEAMS=1
claude

# Or in settings.json
{
  "env": { "CLAUDE_CODE_EXPERIMENTAL_AGENT_TEAMS": "1" }
}
```

Then in Claude Code:

Create an agent team with 3 reviewers for the latest PR:

- Security reviewer: focus on auth and data leaks
- Performance reviewer: focus on N+1 queries and memory
- Test reviewer: focus on coverage gaps and edge cases

Background Agents (Simpler)

Run a background agent to check test coverage while I continue working.

Background agents run in the current session and return results when done.

Agent Teams Workflow

Step 1: Create Team

Ask Claude to create a team. It spawns: – **Lead session** (you) – coordinates
– **Teammate sessions** – independent Claude instances – **Shared task list** – visible to all – **Mailbox** – for inter-agent messaging

Step 2: Assign Tasks

Assign the frontend review to the UX reviewer.
Let each teammate self-claim available tasks.

Step 3: Navigate Between Teammates

Shift+Down → Cycle through teammates
Shift+Down → Back to lead (wraps around)
Type message → Send to currently focused teammate

Step 4: Monitor Progress

Show me the task list and status of all teammates.

Step 5: Shutdown

Ask the researcher teammate to shut down.
Clean up the team. # Only works after all teammates are stopped

Display Modes

Mode	Setup	Best for
in-process (default)	None	Any terminal. Teammates share one window
tmux	brew install tmux	Split panes, see all agents at once
auto	–	Uses tmux if available, else in-process

```
claude --teammate-mode tmux    # Force tmux mode
claude --teammate-mode auto    # Auto-detect (default)
```

In tmux mode, each teammate gets its own pane. iTerm2 uses native split panes.

Background Agents

Simpler than teams – no coordination, just fire-and-forget:

Run a background agent to:

1. Find all TODO comments in the codebase
2. Categorize by priority
3. Create a summary

Background agents: – Run concurrently in your session – Pre-approve permissions upfront – Return results when done – Can be killed with **Ctrl+F** (two presses to confirm)

Background vs Team

	Background Agent	Team Teammate
Context	Shares session	Own context window
Communication	Returns summary	Mailbox + task list
Coordination	None	Lead coordinates
Use case	One-off tasks	Parallel sustained work

Configuration

Define Custom Agents

// CLI flag

```
claude --agents '{"reviewer": {"description": "Reviews code", "prompt": "You are a
```

// Or in settings.json

```
{
  "agents": {
    "security-reviewer": {
      "description": "Security-focused reviewer",
      "prompt": "Focus on OWASP top 10, auth, data leaks",
      "model": "opus"
    }
  }
}
```

Worktree Isolation for Teammates

Spawn a teammate with worktree isolation to refactor the auth module. Each teammate can work in its own worktree, preventing file conflicts.

Permissions

- Teammates inherit lead's permissions at spawn
 - Can override per teammate after spawning (Shift+Down → Shift+Tab)
 - `--dangerously-skip-permissions` applies to all teammates
-

Real-World Workflows

Workflow 1: Parallel PR Review (3 Reviewers)

Create an agent team for PR #142:

Reviewer 1 (Security):

- Check auth flows, token handling, input validation
- Look for injection risks, data leaks

Reviewer 2 (Performance):

- Profile hotspots, check for N+1 queries
- Review algorithm efficiency, memory usage

Reviewer 3 (Tests):

- Verify coverage, check edge cases
- Look for flaky tests, missing assertions

Have each reviewer report findings, then synthesize a final review.

Workflow 2: Parallel Feature Implementation

Create a team:

- Backend agent: Add new `/api/notifications` endpoint with tests
- Frontend agent: Build `NotificationBell` component with Storybook
- Each should work in a worktree to avoid conflicts

Workflow 3: Background Linting While Working

- > Run a background agent to lint all TypeScript files and fix auto-fixable issues.
 - > [continue working on your feature]
 - > [background agent returns: "Fixed 23 lint issues across 8 files"]
-

How It Interacts With Other Features

Feature	Interaction
Worktrees	Teammates can each work in isolated worktrees
Session Resume	Teammates are NOT preserved on resume (must respawn)
Hooks	TeammateIdle and TaskCompleted hooks for quality gates
MCP Servers	Teammates inherit lead's MCP servers
Skills	Teammates can invoke skills available to lead
Plugins	Teammates inherit enabled plugins
Permissions	Inherited from lead at spawn, overridable per teammate

Gotchas & Tips

1. **Research preview** – requires `CLAUDE_CODE_EXPERIMENTAL_AGENT_TEAMS=1`. Expect rough edges.
2. **Teammates lose history on resume** – `/resume` does NOT restore teammates. You'll need to respawn them.
3. **Non-overlapping work** – give teammates distinct, non-overlapping tasks. Same-file edits without worktrees will conflict.
4. **3–5 teammates optimal** – coordination overhead increases beyond 5. Token usage scales linearly.
5. **Detailed spawn prompts** – teammates don't inherit conversation history. Include specific file paths, line references, and full context in their spawn prompt.
6. **One team per session** – can't spawn multiple teams. Teammates can't spawn their own teams (no nesting).
7. **tmux cleanup** – if cleanup fails, check with `tmux ls` and `tmux kill-session -t <name>`.
8. **Ctrl+F** – two presses to kill all background agents. Single press shows confirmation.
9. **Shift+Down wraps** – after last teammate, cycles back to lead.
10. **Split panes** – not supported in VS Code integrated terminal or Windows Terminal. Use in-process mode.

Version History

Version	Date	Change
v2.0.x	Late 2025	Subagent system (Explore, Plan) – precursor
Feb 5, 2026	v2.1.x	Agent Teams research preview announced
v2.1.45	Feb 2026	Agent Teams fixes on Bedrock, Vertex, Foundry
v2.1.47	Feb 2026	Ctrl+F to kill background agents, concurrent agent fixes
v2.1.49	Feb 2026	Background agents (background: true), isolation: worktree
v2.1.50	Feb 2026	claude agents subcommand, worktree hooks for agents
v2.1.53	Feb 2026	Bulk agent kill (Ctrl+F) notification fix, teammate navigation